PD Reading

November 3, 2026 District PD | Read before the discussion

Drafting a Student Response Matters

Drafting a student response is one of the most powerful things educators can do when planning for learning, because it requires experiencing the thinking students will be asked to do. It moves planning beyond **"What will students do?"** to **"What will students need to know, understand, and independently demonstrate?"**

Why drafting a student response matters

1. **Clarifies the depth of the grade-level standard.** Completing the task reveals whether it truly requires the reasoning, analysis, explanation, and application the standard expects.
2. **Strengthens criteria for success.** Drafting identifies the specific evidence of learning that should be visible in student work, making quality concrete rather than abstract.
3. **Reveals the cognitive demand of the task.** Experiencing the thinking shows whether students are appropriately challenged or whether the task is too scaffolded, too simple, or focused mainly on completion.
4. **Anticipates student thinking and misconceptions.** Working through the task predicts where students may struggle, which misconceptions may emerge, and where productive struggle is essential.
5. **Identifies academic language demands.** Educators can name the interpretive and expressive language students need to access the task, explain reasoning, and demonstrate understanding, aligned to the language objective and WIDA standards.
6. **Prepares educators to give actionable feedback.** Knowing what a strong response requires makes gaps in student thinking easier to recognize and easier to address with specific feedback that moves learning forward without doing the thinking for students.
7. **Strengthens collaborative calibration.** When educators draft and compare responses together, they build a shared understanding of what meeting the grade-level standard actually looks like.
8. **Supports independent demonstration of learning.** Drafting clarifies what students must ultimately demonstrate on their own and which instructional supports should be gradually removed.

What drafting a response is not

Drafting a student response is not about creating an answer key for students to copy. It is about developing a clear understanding of the quality and depth of learning expected, while remaining open to different valid approaches and ways students may demonstrate understanding. **We cannot effectively plan for, recognize, or provide feedback on the depth of student thinking if that thinking has not first been grappled with.**

THE MOST IMPORTANT TAKEAWAY

Student responses are not drafted to make the task easier for students. They are drafted to make instruction, success criteria, and feedback more effective, so students can do the challenging thinking independently.

Discussion questions for course-alike teams

1. Which purpose of drafting a student response matters most for the task students will complete next, and why?
2. Where has drafting a response changed a lesson, a task, or the way feedback was written?
3. What should the benchmark include so students receive clear success criteria and useful, actionable feedback?
4. Which supports can be planned now so that every student has access to the task while the cognitive demand stays at grade level?